Should Abortion Be Permitted?

The question surrounding whether abortion should be permitted in various circumstances is a contentious one, as it raises ethical and practical concerns. Some may argue that abortion can be endorsed due to the fear of religious indictments and the obligation to follow society's values or norms. However, in this article, the pro-life view will be labelled as untenable, as abortion should be assisted by implementing the ethical theory of utilitarianism and the concept of bodily autonomy. Therefore, it will instead be argued that abortion should be permitted, highlighting how the pro-choice perspective will be expressed succinctly in this article.

The Influence of Religion and Society

The concept of abortion can evoke a certain fear and immediate disapproval within individuals. Why might a medical procedure be met with such a reaction? Most members of society have a staunch outlook on religion, where religion governs their views and actions. Christian teachings are influential and pervasive, such as the Ten Commandments, where the ruling, "Thou shalt not kill", is heavily emphasised, correlating with the 'sanctity of life' God has given them. How does this affect their stance on abortion? People with conservative Christian beliefs may oppose abortion as they may feel fearful of the consequences of violating religious laws. Apart from religion, society itself has its own ethos in which a person may be susceptible to. How may this affect their belief on abortion?

Society can enforce stereotypes towards individuals present within the community. The most embedded assumption within society, that can still be observed today, is based on the notion of femininity. What does society state on the role of women? Throughout history, the ideal woman has connotations of nurture, care, and maternal instincts that are seen to be innate within them. They are focused on the sphere of domesticity where they are responsible and subjected to being altruistic, balancing the needs of their offspring and their husband. Abortion, can therefore be argued, is not an option. Eradicating a life of a foetus can awaken societal stigma, where the depiction of an independent, empowered woman does not adhere to society's traditional gender norms. Abortion would be seen as an act of transgression, as under no circumstance should a woman reject her maternal roles and instead should commit to raising that child lovingly. But does that mean that society and religion should dictate every sole action we execute?

Utilitarianism and Individual Choice

Yet, even though some may argue that the concept of religion and societal control play a part when debating the topic of abortion, moral and ethical principles can overturn them. Individual choice and free will should be asserted within today's day and age, where prominent structures restrict people in expressing their own actions. How can an individual subvert these conventions? They can shift their views into prioritising themselves, highlighting by the concept

of utilitarianism that prescribes actions that maximise happiness and well-being for the affected individuals. If a woman decides that having an abortion is the best choice for her, what can stop her use of free will? The potency of self-determination should be the only method when making such life-changing decisions, unlike institutions forcing people to conform to the doctrines they believe are correct. Except for ethical principles, why else may abortion be permitted?

Bodily Autonomy and Women's Rights

Like stated before, in society, women have been devoid of bodily autonomy. This idea can be toppled by the changes that have emerged within society. Article 8 of the Human Rights Act protects the right of dignity and autonomy of all citizens within the UK, and the right to respect family and private life. Even though some may argue that this article does not directly permit women to have abortions on a larger scale, female liberation can be viewed by significant laws, such as the Equal Pay Act of 1970 and the Sex Discrimination Act of 1975. If laws can authorise and recognise female equality, why do societal expectations limit women’s potential? Abortion should be allowed, in order to subvert the systemic gender norms placed on women, and for them to have the choice of their actions.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the function of religion and society when considering abortion is seen to violate the rights of an individual, as even though they are distinguished structures in society, their principles stand in stark contrast with individual choice and free will. Therefore, in such evolving societies, abortion should be permitted as personal choices should be reliant on the stance of the woman herself, in order to instil a sense of confidence and self-prioritisation.